

Ancla can now say what changed, row by row

We keep a daily copy of the national procurement record, fingerprint it, and anchor it on chain. From today you can also see what changed between one copy and the next.

● decentralamerica.com/evidencia

190

monthly archives
Dec 2010 – Sep 2026

~6M

records
queryable history

400+

anchored fingerprints
on DecentralChain

<\$1

per year
running cost

What Ancla is

The Costa Rican state publishes all of its public procurement as open data. That file is updated every day at the same web address, and when it is published again, the previous version stops existing.

Ancla keeps a daily copy before that happens. It fingerprints each copy and writes that fingerprint to DecentralChain, where nobody can change it afterwards. If the file is rewritten, there is an earlier copy to compare it against and a date nobody controls.

It now holds 190 monthly archives, December 2010 to September 2026, around six million records. More than 400 fingerprints are anchored on chain. Running it costs under a dollar a year.

What changed since August

On 27 August we published that archives of already-closed months had been rewritten five times, fourteen months in total. That piece ended by admitting a limit: we knew the files had changed, not what changed inside them. A fingerprint covers the whole file, not each row.

That is now solved. Ancla keeps every full version, compares them row by row, and publishes the result as a bundle anyone can rebuild and check themselves.

How it works

Four steps, every day:

- 01 **Copy.** The month's archive is downloaded and stored without overwriting anything. A new copy is stored beside the old one, never on top of it.
- 02 **Reduce.** Each record becomes two fingerprints: one that moves if anything at all moves, and one that ignores formatting. An amount published as 1.000 and republished as 1 is the same amount written differently, and reporting that as tampering would be noise.
- 03 **Anchor.** Every fingerprint in the month folds into a single 64-character one, written to DecentralChain. The chain holds no contracts, no names, no amounts: it holds the fingerprint, a record count, and a date.
- 04 **Compare.** If the archive is rewritten, it is compared against the previous copy and every difference is classified: new record, amendment the source declared, silent revision, withdrawal, or formatting only.

What you can see today

decentralamerica.com/evidencia lists every copy held, the fingerprint of each, and whether that fingerprint is committed on chain.

Where two copies of the same period exist, the page shows the comparison. It leads with what usually matters: which fields moved, and how. In the August 2026 comparison, between the copy served on the 26th and the one served on the 31st, there are 7,592 silent revisions, 3,678 withdrawn records, and 117 rows where an amount moved. That last number is the one a reader is looking for, and it was unfindable by scrolling a list of 260,000 changes.

The page does not ask you to trust it. The fingerprint is recomputed in your own browser and checked against the chain, reading the public node directly. If our server altered a single number, the check would fail on your screen.

Who it is useful for

A supplier who wants to know whether the record of their tender changed after publication. A journalist following a contract. A lawyer who filed an objection and needs the state of the file on a specific date. An auditor who needs to cite a version rather than the current one.

And anyone who wants to check for themselves that the public record still says today what it said yesterday.

What it proves and what it does not

Ancla proves that a published record changed, and from when. That is the entire claim.

It does not prove any change was improper. Correcting a badly loaded field produces exactly the same signal as altering one on purpose, and from outside they look identical. It does not detect corruption: it detects change.

It cannot audit the past either. Anchoring establishes integrity forward, from the day it starts. For the fourteen months rewritten before August 2026, no earlier copy exists anywhere, and that is permanent. The tool says so, period by period, rather than papering over it.

And it only sees what gets published. The Contraloría estimated that in 2021, 27.1% of awarded value moved outside the platform. Ancla cannot measure that: you cannot detect an absence in a dataset that only records presence.

Where the data comes from

From SICOP, run by the Ministerio de Hacienda, and SIAC, run by the Contraloría General de la República. Both are republished by the Observatorio de Compra Pública at observatoriocomprapublica.go.cr, which publishes them for "análisis, seguimiento, fiscalización y el desarrollo de nuevas aplicaciones". This is exactly that use, on the data as the state hands it over.

Ancla is not a state project. The data is. That distinction is the point: an oversight instrument operated by the institution being observed proves nothing. The value is that nobody at Hacienda can change what Ancla

already recorded, and neither can we.

All the code is open, MIT licensed.

What comes next

Panamá joined on 3 September. That is 37 months of PanamaCompra since September 2023, with the same treatment and the same fingerprints on the same account. No Panamanian period has been rewritten yet, which is the good outcome: there is nothing to compare.

Honduras is out for now. Its portal has served an expired certificate since 5 July 2026, so the download cannot be authenticated, and without that a copy only proves somebody handed us some bytes. Guatemala publishes the data but requires passing an access control its operator turned on deliberately; the route there is to request access, not to work around it. El Salvador and Nicaragua publish no bulk archive at all, so no tool can reach them.

One question remains that is larger than the software. Whoever holds the key that signs the fingerprints is the credibility of the system, and today that key is ours. It belongs with an institution that has no stake in procurement outcomes: a university, a professional college, a newsroom. That is a governance decision rather than an engineering one, and it is the largest open risk in the project.

CHECK IT YOURSELF

The copies and the comparisons	decentralamerica.com/evidencia
The account that signs the fingerprints	<code>3DTwG5ZydbJDuLdEmwfgDEH3NuWDrigwQFtF</code>
The code, MIT licensed	github.com/dylanpersonguy/ancla
Where the data comes from	observatoriocomprapublica.go.cr